

not as farmers, but as tradesmen, merchants, doctors, teachers, and moneylenders. Frequently, if not generally, they were denied ownership of land. They couldn't plant trees. They couldn't plant anything. Often, they didn't have the need to "save the seed corn." You'd think they would be the biggest spendthrifts and "live for today" crowd on Earth. But they are not. They are careful with wealth. And extremely forward-looking. Why?

Well, one thing that comes readily to mind is that Jews are also extremely oriented toward their own history. And history is a kind of future in reverse. Perhaps it gave them the same focus on the need for preparedness.

Jewish history is a long story of disasters, one after another. Many of those disasters involved avoiding extermination by fleeing. And fleeing costs money. The Jews, perhaps more than anyone, had to think ahead. They had to be prepared. At any minute, the heavy boot of the state or the mob might come down on them. They could not plant trees. But they accumulated wealth, often in the form of gold and diamonds. It is no coincidence that they are the world's leading moneymen today.

In fact, with the Jews in mind, we might broaden our hypothesis into a general theory:

Adversity leads a people to appreciate preparedness. Wealth is preparation in negotiable form.

The first chapter of this book addresses the objection: Why would you bother? Can't we safely assume that the supply channels will keep the supermarket shelves stocked, winter and summer? Aren't the pogroms over? Isn't the desire to stockpile grain—or wealth—for generations a bit useless and anachronistic, like a prehensile tail? Besides, it would be so much more fun to spend your money now, wouldn't it?

Assuming you have jumped that hurdle, the following chapters suggest ways to do it.

Not that we, your authors, are experts on the subject. We are just learning. But we happily pass along what we think we have learned and/or figured out on our own. Whether it is correct or not—or whether it is useful or not—you will have to judge for yourself.

But the main point is worth keeping in mind: This book is not about getting something. It is about giving up something. It is for the planter. For the roofer. For the builder. For the saver. It is for the person who wishes to